## Cookies on GOV.UK Design System

We'd like to use analytics cookies so we can understand how you use the Design System and make improvements.

We also use essential cookies to remember if you've accepted analytics cookies.

Accept analytics cookies | Reject analytics cookies | View cookies (/cookies/)



Ask users for…

- Addresses (/patterns/addresses/)
- Bank details (/patterns/bank-details/)
- Dates (/patterns/dates/)
- Email addresses (/patterns/email-addresses/)
- Equality information (/patterns/equality-information/)
- Names (/patterns/names/)
- National Insurance numbers

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Home > Patterns

Help users to

# Complete multiple tasks

Help users understand:

- the tasks involved in completing a transaction
- the order they should complete tasks in
- when they've completed tasks

Open this example in a new tab (/patterns/complete-multiple-tasks/default/)

(/patterns/national-insurance-numbers/)

Passwords (/patterns/passwords/)

Payment card details (/patterns/payment-card-details/)

Phone numbers (/patterns/phone-numbers/)

Help users to…

Check a service is suitable (/patterns/check-a-service-is-suitable/)

Check answers (/patterns/check-answers/)

**Complete multiple tasks (/patterns/complete-multiple-tasks/)**

Confirm a phone number (/patterns/confirm-a-phone-number/)

Confirm an email address (/patterns/confirm-an-email-address/)

Contact a department or service team (/patterns/contact-a-department-or-service-team/)

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GOV·UK

# Service name

## Check before you start

| | |
|---|---|
| Check eligibility | Completed |
| Read declaration | Incomplete |

## Prepare application

| | |
|---|---|
| Company information | Completed |
| Your contact details | Incomplete |
| List convictions | Completed |
| Provide financial evidence | Incomplete |
| Give medical information | Incomplete |

Apply

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Create a username (/patterns/create-a-username/)

Create accounts (/patterns/create-accounts/)

Exit a page quickly (/patterns/exit-a-page-quickly/)

Navigate a service (/patterns/navigate-a-service/)

Recover from validation errors (/patterns/validation/)

Start using a service (/patterns/start-using-a-service/)

Pages

Confirmation pages (/patterns/confirmation-pages/)

Cookies page (/patterns/cookies-page/)

Interruption pages (/patterns/interruption-pages/)

Page not found pages (/patterns/page-not-found-pages/)

Question pages (/patterns/question-

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| |
|---|
| HTML |
| Nunjucks |

Complete multiple tasks pages use a Task list component (/components/task-list) for each group of tasks on the page.

# When to use this pattern

Only use a complete multiple tasks page for longer transactions involving multiple tasks that users may need to complete over a number of sessions.

Try to simplify the transaction before you use a complete multiple tasks page. If you're able to reduce the number of tasks or steps involved, you might not need one.

# How it works

You should show a complete multiple tasks page:

- at the start of the transaction
- at the start of each returning session

If you use a complete multiple tasks page in your service, you'll need to:

- group related actions into tasks
- show the status of the tasks

If there are lots of tasks to complete, you might also need to group them further into steps.

## Show related actions as a task

pages/)

Service unavailable pages (/patterns/service-unavailable-pages/)

Step by step navigation (/patterns/step-by-step-navigation/)

There is a problem with the service pages (/patterns/problem-with-the-service-pages/)

Summarise a set of related activities and questions into a task, for example, ‘Provide financial evidence’ and ‘Give medical information’. This will help users understand and plan what they need to do.

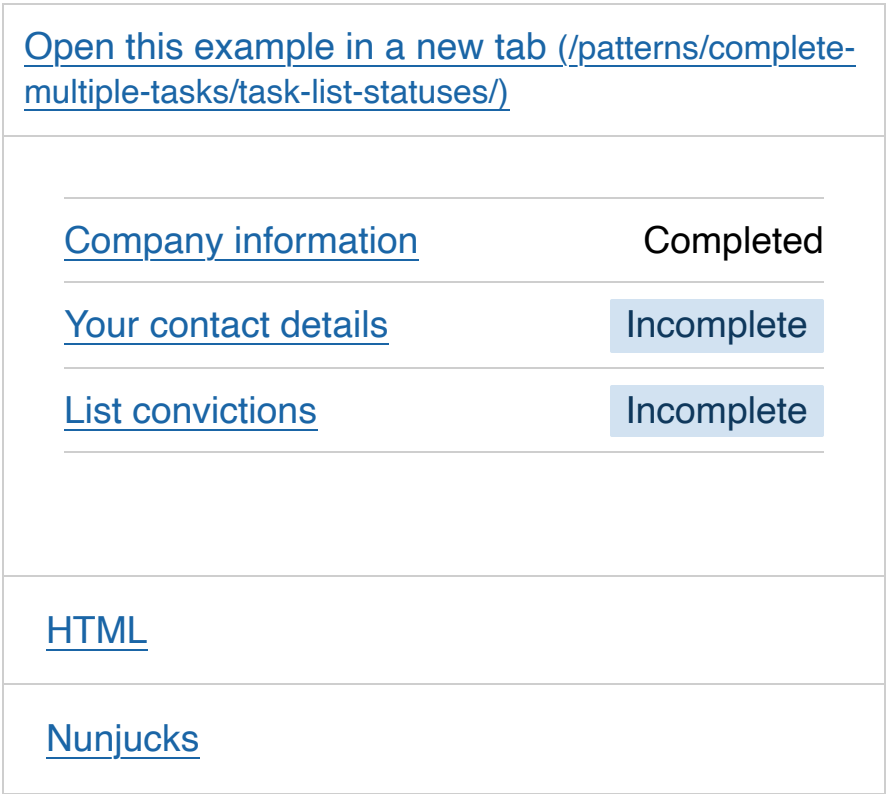
Where possible, task names should:

- describe what the task or activity will involve
- start with verbs, for example, ‘check’, ‘declare’, ‘report’

## Show the status of the tasks

Make it clear to users which tasks they’ve completed and which still need their attention, by labelling them using statuses.

Open this example in a new tab (/patterns/complete-multiple-tasks/task-list-statuses/)




HTML

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Statuses should be helpful to users. The more you add, the harder it is for users to remember them. Start with the smallest number of different statuses you think might work, for example ‘Completed’ and ‘Incomplete’, then add more if your user research shows there’s a need for them.

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Once the user has completed the task, the status should show as ‘Completed’ and be black text with no background colour. This will draw more attention to tasks that require action.

### Tasks that are in progress

You may find you need additional statuses if your user research shows that users want to be able to distinguish between the tasks they haven’t started at all, and those they’ve started but not completed.

In this instance, instead of ‘Incomplete’, you may want to use ‘Not yet started’ to show which tasks they are yet to start. You should then use ‘In progress’ for tasks they have started but are yet to complete.

Different colours may be used to further differentiate between tags.

Open this example in a new tab (/components/task-list/in-progress/)

| | |
|---|---|
| Contact details | Completed |
| Work history | In progress |
| Qualifications | Not yet started |
| Supporting statement | Not yet started |

HTML

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### Tasks that cannot yet be started

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If the user cannot start the task yet, for example because another task must be completed first, use the ‘Cannot start yet’ status. This should be grey text with no background colour, and the ‘task row’ should not be linked.

Open this example in a new tab (/components/task-list/cannot-start-yet/)

| | |
|---|---|
| Company details | Completed |
| Project details | Incomplete |
| Fund applied to<br>The funds will be announced on 1 April 2022 | Cannot start yet |

HTML

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**Tasks containing an error**

You should avoid tasks having an error status by using the Error summary component (/components/error-summary/) and Error message component (/components/error-message/) displayed at the point that the error is made, so that the user can fix it straight away.

If it is unavoidable that a task may end up saved but containing an error, use the status text ‘There is a problem’ and a red background.

Do not use the red background colour for any status text except errors.

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Open this example in a new tab (/components/task-list/error/)

| | |
|---|---|
| Contact details | Completed |
| Project details | Incomplete |
| Funding required | There is a problem |
| Bank account | Completed |

HTML

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### Status text

Although we recommend using consistent wording across task lists, you can change it if research shows that different text is more suitable to your service or users.

If you are creating your own statuses, use adjectives rather than verbs. Use sentence case, and keep it short, so that it can be easily read and understood.

### Additional statuses

If your user research shows that there is a need for additional status tags, you can use other colours to help distinguish between them.

Open this example in a new tab (/components/task-list/all-colours/)

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| | |
|---|---|
| Task A | Grey |
| Task B | Green |
| Task C | Teal |
| Task D | Blue |
| Task E | Purple |
| Task F | Magenta |
| Task G | Orange |
| Task H | Yellow |

HTML

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## Group tasks into steps

If your transaction involves lots of tasks, make it manageable by splitting it up into steps that represent stages in the process.

For example, you could group all tasks which help users find out if your service is right for them in a step called ‘Check before you start’.

Where possible, allow users to complete tasks in any order. This will help them plan their time and complete sections as and when they can.

## Marking tasks as completed

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Sometimes, it's better to let the user decide when a task is completed.

This can be helpful when a task involves:

- some questions that are optional
- writing a long answer (such as in a Textarea component (/components/textarea/))
- looking up information, such as details about previous jobs
- answers that need to be checked carefully with someone else

Do this by asking a radio question at the end of the task – either as the last question (if the task is a single page) or on the Check answers page (/patterns/check-answers/) (if the task involves more than one page).

Ask 'Have you completed this section?' with the radio options 'Yes, I've completed this section' or 'No, I'll come back later'.

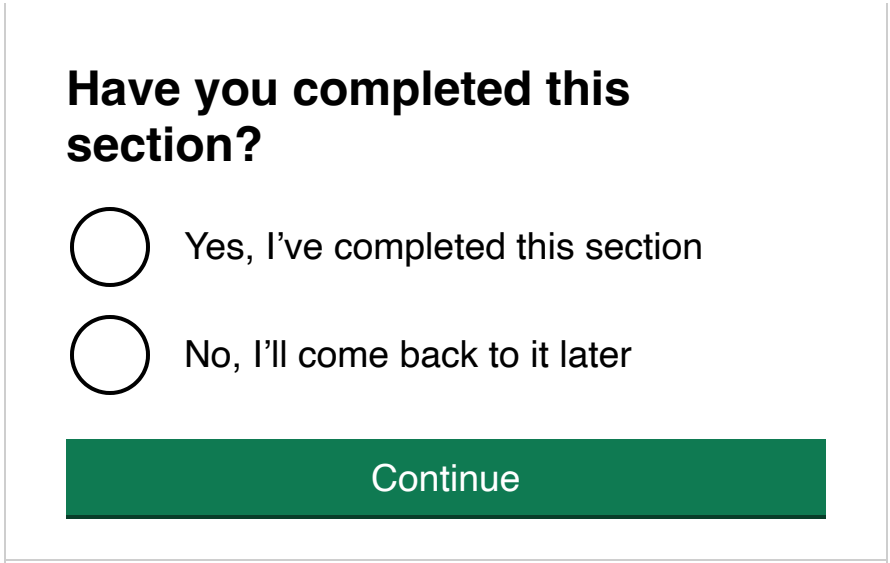
If the user selects 'No, I'll come back to it later,' mark the task as 'Incomplete' or 'In progress'.

If the user selects 'Yes, I've completed this section,' mark the task as 'Completed'.

Open this example in a new tab (/patterns/complete-multiple-tasks/have-you-completed-this-section/)



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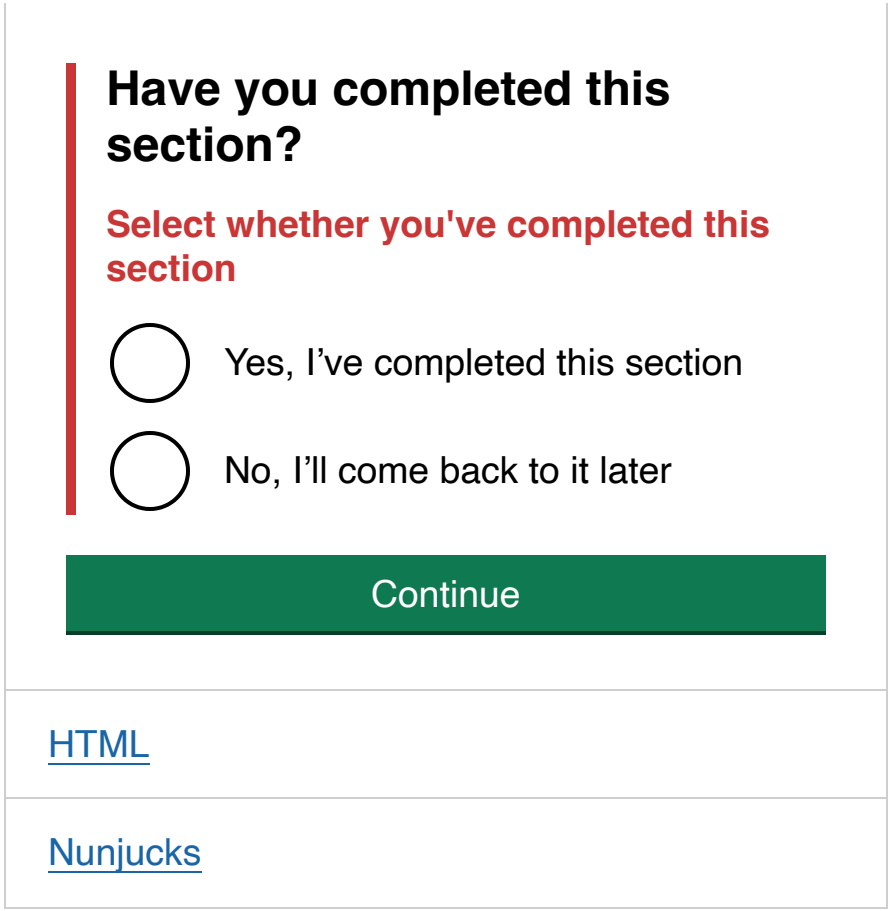
Always allow users to go back into a task to change their answer.

### Error messages

If the user does not select an option, show an Error message component (/components/error-message/) to say: 'Select whether you've completed this section'.

Open this example in a new tab (/patterns/complete-multiple-tasks/have-you-completed-this-section-error/)

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# Research on this pattern

This pattern was previously named 'Task list' and was developed by a team at the Government Digital Service (GDS) (https://designnotes.blog.gov.uk/2017/04/04/weve-published-the-task-list-pattern/).

It was then iterated by a cross-government collaboration and published as a new Task list component (/components/task-list/) with updated guidance and research.

See the research on the Task list component (/components/task-list#research-on-this-component) for details of research done, and known issues and gaps.

# Help improve this pattern

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To help make sure that this page is useful, relevant and up to date, you can:

- take part in the 'Complete multiple tasks' discussion on GitHub (https://github.com/alphagov/govuk-design-system/discussions/6251/) and share your research
- propose a change on GitHub (https://github.com/alphagov/govuk-design-system/edit/main/src/patterns/complete-multiple-tasks/index.md) – read more about how to propose changes in GitHub (/community/propose-a-content-change-using-github/)

## Need help?

If you've got a question about the GOV.UK Design System, contact the team (/contact/).



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